



# Granular Acceptance Criteria

Week 3 • Day 2 • Requirements Engineering & Mini-Capstone

TPM Academy



## Day 2 Objectives

- Write acceptance criteria (AC) in **Given/When/Then** form — testable, falsifiable, scoped
- Detect and rewrite the **5 AC failure modes**
- Cover **happy path / sad path / weird path** — the discipline that distinguishes TPM AC from PM AC
- Conduct an **AC cross-review** with another quad
- Add a **review-resolution note** documenting what was adopted, deferred, or rejected



# Today's Shape

| Clock         | Block                       | Outcome                                 |
|---------------|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 09:00 – 09:15 | Opening                     | Restate non-AI rule; recap Day 1 output |
| 09:15 – 10:30 | Block 1 + Activity 1        | AC Triage                               |
| 10:45 – 12:00 | Block 2 + Activity 2        | Happy-path AC                           |
| 13:00 – 14:15 | Block 3 + Activity 3        | Sad & weird-path AC                     |
| 14:30 – 16:00 | Block 4 + Activity 4 + Wrap | AC Cross-Review                         |

# Block 1 — What an AC Is

And the 5 ways AC most often fail



# The Given/When/Then Form

```
Given <a precondition / starting state>  
When <an action or event happens>  
Then <an observable, falsifiable result>
```

| Is                                                | Is not                            |
|---------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Testable (you can write a test that passes/fails) | "The system should be intuitive"  |
| Specific to one behavior                          | "The system handles errors well"  |
| Implementation-agnostic                           | "Use Redis to cache the response" |
| Falsifiable (you can prove it wrong)              | "Performance should be good"      |



# The Five AC Failure Modes

| Failure                        | Example                             | Fix                                |
|--------------------------------|-------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| 1. Vague                       | "Then it loads quickly"             | Replace with measurable target     |
| 2. Untestable                  | "Then user feels confident"         | Anchor to system-visible state     |
| 3. Restating goal              | "Then dispatchers reconcile faster" | Pin to in-system event, not metric |
| 4. AND-soup                    | "Then X and Y and Z and W"          | Split into multiple ACs            |
| 5. Implementation-prescriptive | "Redis cache hit returns..."        | Behavior, not implementation       |

# Activity 1 — AC Triage

Quads • 45 minutes

You receive 12 AC examples. For each, identify which failure mode(s) are present (or "clean"). Rewrite the failed ones.

- 30 min: triage all 12
- 10 min: rewrite the failed ones
- 5 min: identify the most common failure mode in your pack



20 triage • 10 rewrite • 5 reflect

# Block 2 — Happy-Path AC

Easiest first; get them out of the way



# Happy / Sad / Weird Path Coverage

| Path  | Question                                                                          | Typical AC count |
|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| Happy | What does success look like end-to-end?                                           | 3–5              |
| Sad   | What happens when input is wrong, user lacks permission, etc.?                    | 2–4              |
| Weird | What about network drops, race conditions, edge cases the user wouldn't think of? | 2–4              |

**The TPM differentiator:** the weird-path coverage. PMs who don't think technically miss it. Engineers who don't think about users miss it differently.

## Worked Happy-Path Example

```
Given a dispatcher viewing the end-of-shift summary  
When they tap "Reconcile all"  
Then the reconcile modal opens within 1 second  
and shows all open tickets pre-selected  
and the header shows the count of tickets selected
```

**Note:** the multiple "and"s here describe one observable state, not separate behaviors. Judgment call — if the "ands" represent different system actions, split.

## Activity 2 — Happy-Path AC

Quads • 50 minutes

Identify the happy path from your Section 5. Each member solo-drafts 3 AC.  
Pool, de-dupe, refine to 3–5 final.

- 5 min: identify the happy path
- 25 min: solo drafts (3 each)
- 15 min: pool + refine
- 5 min: 5-failure-mode check



5 + 25 + 15 + 5

# Block 3 — Sad & Weird Paths

Where TPMs earn their seat

# Sad-Path Generator

For each happy-path AC, ask:

- What if the **input is invalid**?
- What if the **user lacks permission**?
- What if the **user cancels mid-flow**?
- What if the **data is missing or stale**?

```
Given a dispatcher with 0 open tickets
When they tap "Reconcile all"
Then a non-modal toast appears with text "No tickets to reconcile"
and the dispatcher remains on the summary screen
```



# Weird-Path Generator

For each happy-path AC, ask:

- What if the **network drops** mid-action?
- What if **two users do the same thing simultaneously** (race)?
- What if the action **takes longer than expected** (timeout)?
- What if the **upstream system is down**?
- What if the user is at the **boundary** (max, min, empty)?

```
Given a dispatcher with 47 open tickets (more than modal can list)
When they tap "Reconcile all"
Then the modal opens with the first 25 tickets pre-selected
and a banner reads "22 more tickets – load more"
and a tap on the banner appends the next 25 below
```

## Activity 3 — Sad & Weird AC

Quads • 50 minutes

Each member produces 2 sad + 2 weird AC. Pool, cull to 4–6 (2–4 sad, 2–4 weird). Run the 5-failure check.

- 20 min: solo sad-path drafts
- 10 min: solo weird-path drafts
- 10 min: pool + cull
- 10 min: failure-mode check



20 + 10 + 10 + 10

# Block 4 — AC Cross-Review

Apply the calibrated eye to another quad's AC





# Why Cross-Review Now

Friday's review covers the whole Product Requirements Document (PRD). Today's review covers **just AC**. Two reasons:

1. AC are where most PRD weakness shows up — fixing them mid-week leaves time for the rest
2. Reviewing another's AC sharpens your eye for your own remaining gaps

**Today's review is informal:** no scoring, no rubric. The point is feedback, not grading.



# The Review Protocol

1. **Pair quads** (instructor assigns)
2. **Swap PRDs** (reviewer reads Sections 1–5 first for context, then Section 6)
3. **Identify failures and gaps:** failure mode? path missing? implicit AC unwritten?
4. **Author quad responds:** adopt / defer / push back, with reasoning
5. **Authors revise** + write the resolution note

**Reviewer rule:** "this could be more specific" is unhelpful. If you say it, you also write the specific version.



# The Review-Resolution Note

At the bottom of Section 6, document what changed and why:

```
## Review-resolution note (Day 2)

**Reviewers:** Quad B
**Findings:**
1. AC #3 was vague ("loads fast") – REWROTE with explicit 1-sec target
2. Missing weird-path AC for offline submit – ADDED as AC #11
3. AC #7 was implementation-prescriptive – REWROTE in user terms

**Deferred:**
- Reviewer suggested AC for "user clicks back button" – DEFERRED to NFR
discussion Day 3 (more about state preservation than acceptance)

**Pushed back:**
- Reviewer suggested splitting AC #2 – DECLINED. Original "and"
describes one observable state, not multiple behaviors.
```

## Activity 4 — AC Cross-Review

Quad pairs • 55 minutes • Wrap

Pair with another quad. Swap PRDs. Review their AC. Author quad responds. Revise and write the resolution note.

- 5 min: read their Sections 1–5
- 25 min: review their Section 6 with the 5 failures + path coverage in mind
- 10 min: author quad responds
- 15 min: revise + write resolution note



5 + 25 + 10 + 15 • 15-min wrap



## Day 2 Wrap

### What we built

- 5-failure-mode AC detector
- Happy/sad/weird path coverage
- 8–12 AC per PRD
- Cross-review + resolution note

### What opens tomorrow

- **Non-Functional Requirements (NFR)**
- Performance, security, accessibility, observability, compliance
- NFRs as constraints, not wishlists

**Bring to Day 3:** Your PRD with Sections 1–6 complete. NFRs come tomorrow.

# Questions & Reflection

Which one of your AC would survive a hostile engineer reading it?